state that, at least constitutionally, was not yet ‘secular’. The words ‘secular’ and ‘socialist’ were added to the Preamble by Indira Gandhi in 1976 during the Emergency through the Forty-second Constitutional Amendment.[4]

Many liberals wrongly decried Modi’s decision to lead the Ram Temple ceremony as an abandonment of the Constitution. A political move, it certainly was. Yet, as Yogi Adityanath pointed out in his speech at the consecration ceremony, the construction was ‘within the legal framework, within the democratic and constitutional system and done peacefully’.[5] As the leader of a political party that explicitly listed the construction of the Ram Temple in its election manifesto, Modi was well within his rights to front such a construction once the Supreme Court ruled in favour of it (however flawed many thought the court’s unanimous 5–0 judgement was).[6]

The fact is that, by 2020, the BJP had won the culture war on Ram. Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi’s message welcoming Ram Lalla and genuflecting before his image, Manish Tiwari’s social media recitation of a Ram bhajan, Kamal Nath changing his Twitter profile picture to that of a Hindu pilgrim reciting the Hanuman Chalisa —all of this reflected the tricky position that the Congress found itself in. It chose to side with the Ram Temple, but stood to gain nothing politically from being the BJP’s B-team on Hinduness.

Modi, meanwhile, sought to appropriate Ram within the reframing of a new ‘Ram Rajya’. Speaking in Ayodhya, he attempted to link the Ram story to his own political project. He spoke of the subterranean shift he had spearheaded within the new BJP: on women and gender relations, on caste and the poor, neatly linking what he posited as the ideals of Ram to his own political messaging. Ram’s appeal was built on the support of those on the margins, Modi argued: ‘vanars and vanvasis’, the poor and women. The promise of this new Ram Rajya was, he said, similarly focused on the lower castes, backward classes and the poor. In a subtle nod to the BJP’s wooing of smaller OBC castes like Rajbhars, Modi explicitly referenced the eleventh-century king Suheldev, revered by both OBC Rajbhars and Dalit Pasis.

One major critique of the Ram Temple movement was that it reduced a multifaceted god to only his angry image. Modi addressed